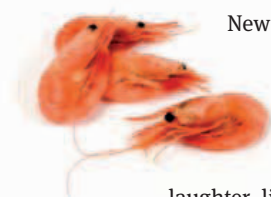




NEW ORLEANS, LOUISIANA USA

Jambalaya in the Big Easy

The mellow notes of a saxophone drift on the warm Gulf breeze through New Orleans' French Quarter, past elaborate wrought-iron balconies toward the jazz bars of Bourbon Street, mingling with the spicy scent of jambalaya wafting from restaurant windows. Welcome to the Big Easy – an extraordinary cultural and culinary melting pot where the good times roll.



New Orleans – nicknamed the Big Easy – is a sultry city that draws its way through the daytime heat but snaps into life after dark, when the

laughter, liquor, and music flow in the bars of the French Quarter. Set along the Mississippi River, it is also a vibrant port, known around the world for its music and its exuberant Mardi Gras festival.

New Orleans is a city of districts, each with its own character. Uptown – home to two universities – has a young vibe, while the Warehouse District offers art lovers the Contemporary Arts Center and Ogden Museum of Southern Art. The Garden District, with its grand antebellum houses, was created by Americans after the 1803 Louisiana Purchase. Its sobriety is a stark contrast to the frenetic French Quarter, where you can see the city's historic Creole townhouses decked with ornate wrought iron, visit antique shops, and enjoy plentiful entertainment.

At night, it's time to explore the city's musical heritage: New Orleans is the home of Dixieland jazz, but you'll also hear big band, jazz fusion, Delta blues, zydeco, funk, and rock music bursting through the doorways on Bourbon Street in the French Quarter.

Jambalaya is the dish that perfectly embodies the city's history. Founded by the French in 1718, New Orleans remained culturally French through subsequent years of Spanish rule, and long after it became an American territory in 1803. The descendants of the French and Spanish settlers – the Creoles – lived alongside African slaves and Haitian refugees, as well as Cajuns, French-speaking exiles from Acadia (present-day Nova Scotia).

Acquiring its name from the Provençal word for “mixture,” jambalaya was born in the French Quarter when Spanish settlers tried to recreate their favorite rice dish, paella, using ripe tomatoes instead of saffron. Caribbean spices such as cayenne enhanced the trinity of peppers, onions, and celery cooked with chicken, peppery *andouille* sausage, and fresh seafood. The result was Creole, or red, jambalaya. Cajun-style brown jambalaya is an earthier version of the dish that gains its color from meat drippings browned in a cast-iron pot. It can contain such wild game foods as crawfish, alligator, duck, or venison. But whether juicy red or smoky brown, the best jambalaya is simmered slowly for an hour or more, allowing the rice to absorb the pungent blend of meat, seafood, and spices that makes it so delicious. The result is a dish both hearty and exotic, much like New Orleans itself.

A Day in New Orleans

With its many museums, plentiful live music, Audubon Zoo, and Aquarium, New Orleans has plenty to offer visiting families, but it is best known as a party city, with festivals throughout the year. The partying reaches frenetic levels during Mardi Gras, or “Fat Tuesday” – a season of carnivals, parades, and masked balls centered around the day before Ash Wednesday.

MORNING See the highlights of the **French Quarter**, including the **Presbytère** and **Cabildo**, **St. Louis Cathedral**, the **French Market**, and **Madame John's Legacy**. There are quirkier attractions, too, such as **Lafitte's Blacksmith Shop** and the **Historic Voodoo Museum**.

AFTERNOON Head to the riverfront in the **Warehouse District** for Blaire Kern's **Mardi Gras World** at Kern Studios. It's the next-best way to experience New Orleans' biggest street party if you can't be there in person.

EVENING Return to the French Quarter and party the night away on **Bourbon Street**.

Essentials

GETTING THERE

Major airlines operate from **Louis Armstrong New Orleans International Airport**, 15 miles (24 km) west of the city.

WHERE TO STAY

Bon Maison Guest House (inexpensive) is a good budget choice at the quiet end of Bourbon Street. www.bonmaison.com

Claiborne Mansion (moderate) has an air of elegance. www.claibornemansion.com

Hotel Monteleone (expensive) is the pick of the French Quarter. www.hotelmonteleone.com

TOURIST INFORMATION

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